

WHAT EVIDENCE IS THERE TO SHOW THAT YOGA REALLY CHANGES OUR BRAINS?

A number of studies have focused on this. One 2015 review of two decades of research found that specific areas of the brain are commonly affected by the yoga-based practice of mindfulness, as shown in the diagram, right. It showed that key areas of the frontal cortex are strengthened, helping you effectively recognize and regulate emotions. Brain scans reported in a different research article, from 2018, also demonstrated that yoga asanas and meditation both reduced amygdala volume on the right-hand side of the brain, which is more associated with negative emotions and fear. In addition, researchers at Stanford University found that eight weeks of mindfulness meditation enabled

people to better reduce fear-related amygdala activity. This seems to work largely as a result of participants being mindful of sensations and emotions instead of pushing them down.

KEY

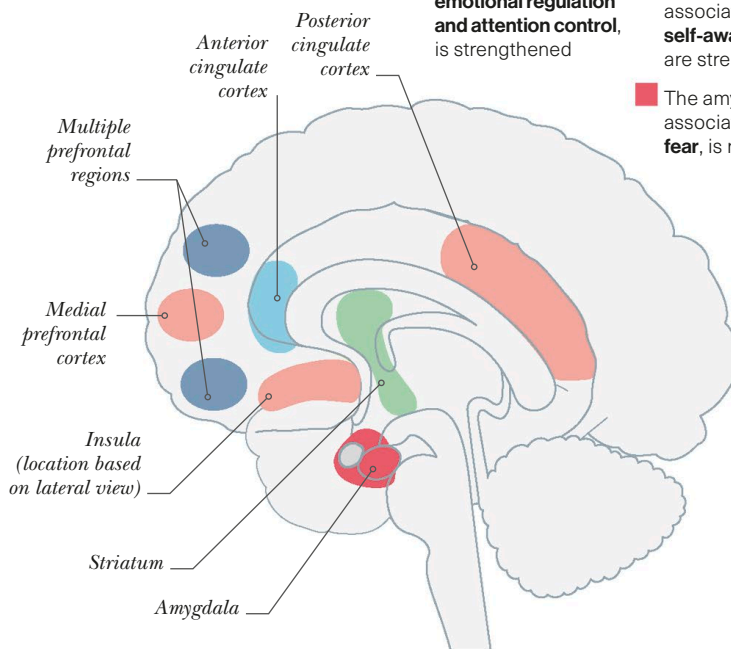
■ Parts of the brain associated with **emotional regulation** are strengthened

■ The striatum, associated with **emotional regulation and attention control**, is strengthened

■ Anterior cingulate cortex, associated with **attention control**, is strengthened

■ Parts of the brain associated with **self-awareness** are strengthened

■ The amygdala, associated with **fear**, is reduced



MIDSAGITTAL VIEW OF THE BRAIN



Did you know?

RESEARCHERS BELIEVE THAT **SOMATIC PRACTICES** (OR MOVEMENT PRACTICES THAT EMPHASIZE **PERCEPTION**, SUCH AS YOGA ASANAS) ARE USEFUL FOR HELPING PEOPLE TO **PROCESS TRAUMA** WITHOUT RETRIGGERING BECAUSE THEY HELP US **RELEASE TENSION** HELD IN THE BODY.